our point of view. Science aspires to objectivity, to a shared point of view about which it is possible to be in agreement.

This is admirable, but we need to be wary about what we lose by ignoring the point of view from which we do the observing. In its anxious pursuit of objectivity, science must not forget that our experience of the world comes from within. Every glance that we cast toward the world is made from a particular perspective.

Taking this fact into account helps to clarify many things. It clarifies, for instance, the relation between what a geographical map tells us and what we actually see. In order to compare the map with what we see, it is necessary to add a crucial piece of information: we must identify on the map our exact location. The map does not know where we are, at least when it is not fixed in the place that it represents—like those maps in mountain villages showing routes that can be walked with a red dot next to which is written: "You Are Here."

A strange phrase: how can a map know where we are? We might be looking at it from afar, through binoculars. Instead, it should say "I, a map, am here," with an arrow next to the red dot. But there is also something curious about a text that refers to itself. What is it?

It is what philosophers call "indexicality": the characteristic of certain words that have a different meaning every time they are used, a meaning determined by where, how, when, and by whom they are being spoken. Words such as "here," "now," "I," "this," "tonight" all assume a different meaning depending on who utters them and the circumstances in which they are uttered. "My name is Carlo Rovelli" is true if I say it, but untrue if someone else not also called Carlo Rovelli uses the same phrase. "Now it is September 12, 2016" is a phrase that's true at the moment that I am writing this but will be false just a few hours later. These indexical phrases make explicit reference to the fact that a point of view exists, that a point of view is an ingredient in every description of the observable world that we make.

If we give a description of the world that ignores point of view, that is solely "from the outside"—of space, of time, of a subject—we may be able to say many things but we lose certain crucial aspects of the world. Because the world that we have been given is the world seen from within it, not from without.

Many things that we see in the world can be understood only if we take into account the role played by point of view. They remain unintelligible if we fail to do so. In every experience, we are situated within the world: within a mind, a brain, a position in space, a moment in time. Our being situated in the world is essential to understanding our experience of time. We must not, in